

Hunters

Act I - Gather

Chapter 1

Staggering through the greyed pavement of the empty streets, her right hand ran across the uneven brick facade of each darkened townhouse dotting the path ahead. Between syncopated breaths she glanced back at her attacker, eyes darting over the bloodstains left on each stone in the ground below her. A chattering like metal teeth echoed through the narrow road, bouncing off each wall as it approached. The woman bounded forward, her voice strained and legs giving out. She had pounded on each door she passed, but knew now that no one would be foolish enough to open themselves up to danger. Gasping for air, she pivoted down a dark alley beside two storefronts, their windows shuddered with iron grating. Her feet danced over the irregular stone path, body pressing against the alley wall for support. She looked up ahead to see a collection of trash bins backed by a large chain fence twice her height. Her heart sputtered, and she could feel the force driving her forward diminish as the adrenaline in her body seeped out of every open wound. She took a few more steps forward, stumbling into the trash heap, and stuck her pale fingers through the holes of the fence. Her knuckles went white as her feeble body clung to its support, legs going numb as her focus shifted to the alley entrance.

The grinding and chattering approached, and the image of a tall figure entered into view, blotting out the light from the streetlamps. Its face was fully clothed in the inky black of night, but its frame looked to be that of a person twice her size, limbs elongated like an ape, hunched over and poised. The creature began to approach, slowly now, seeing her cornered, and as it stepped closer she could see that veneer of shadow slip away. Its face was exceedingly angular, almost pyramid like, with a point in the front that opened up revealing a circle saw of teeth. Its eyes were pure light, incandescent bulbs flashing on and off as it opened and closed its mouth. Her breath was caught in her throat as she pressed further into the chain link fence behind her, vaguely aware of the metal sinking into her back. The creature crossed half the distance between them in two steps, rearing its gangly arms and crouching down like a cat ready to pounce. It seemed to hold for only a moment before lunging forward, her body surging just enough to raise her arms in a futile attempt at self-defence.

Cr—ack!

The collision sent shards of ice splintering out into her slumped frame. Shakily, her arms lowered and head raised, to see the beak of the creature an inch from her face, its tip peaking out from a thick wall of ice which held it in place. The creature pressed its hands against the ice, struggling to free itself from the other side, finally managing to rend its beak and causing the center of the wall to shatter. It shook its head and turned back to the entrance of the alley way, tracing a line of iced over ground from the wall to its origin point. Standing in the middle of the street, slowly rising from her knelt position on the stone, stood a humanoid figure. Her body was blocky and yellow, with a cube shaped head and a fully flat torso. Her eyes were a deep brown, the rest of her face a featureless, flat mask. She raised a rectangular finger to the creature, closing her eyes in a moment of thought. A voice rang out, despite her lacking any mouth for which to speak.

“Kostak, wanted for the killing of 4 men, 8 women, and 1 child. 3,200 Nero dead, 4,000 Nero alive.”

Kostak turned its body now to face the woman in the street, its mouth opening and closing rhythmically as its eyes flashed. Its distended hands reached out to touch the walls of the alley as it fixated on her figure.

“It’s in my best interest not to kill you,” the voice stated plainly, as she extended her fingers, a flash of light blue appearing in her palm. “But that decision is yours to make.”

In a slip moment, Kostak gripped tight to the brick walls and flung itself forward like a rocket, bounding towards the street in less than a second, its mouth opened wide and teeth grinding. The moment its beak exited the alleyway, a shot ripped through the night air, its blast echoing in all directions. The lanky body of Kostak fell to the ground, its head almost entirely removed. Standing just beside it, Melanie lowered the smoking barrel of her shotgun, reholstering it on her back and looking down at the lifeless body. She turned over at Nebakin, who had lowered her hand, its blue light dissipated.

“I don’t know why you think they’ll ever be willing to cooperate.” Her voice was low and soft. Nebakin gazed over the corpse, before leaning her head back at an angle.

“I like for them to know this was their decision.” She turned back to the alley way, the huddled woman staring at her through the hole in the ice wall. Nebakin raised her hand and clenched her fist, the wall immediately shattering into a harmless flurry of snow and crystals.

“You can go now,” she said in a flat tone. The woman remained still. Nebakin turned back to Melanie, who had grabbed hold of the 10 foot corpse, slumping it over her shoulder with a grunt.

“Nearest patrol station is a 20 minute walk, but I don’t exactly want this guy rotting away at our place for the night.” Nebakin merely nodded and walked ahead, Melanie dragging the body behind her as the two paced down the silent stone street.

Chapter 2

The bar was constructed underneath a two story complex, one that had been long abandoned. The first floor used to be a cafe judging by what was left of the disheveled interior and the faded welcome sign hanging above a row of shattered windows. The floor above that was either an apartment or some sort of office, Melanie had only ever done a cursory search of the floor to make sure it was empty. The bar's entrance was located just as you stepped into the alley. A small set of stairs sunk into the ground, leading to a metal door flanked by broken martini shaped LEDs. The light would have only drawn unwanted attention to the duo at this point. Descending past the steps and beyond the door, the floor opened up into a velveteed lounge, couches and stools set up to create separated social circles along the walls. The bar itself was located on the right side of the room, stocked with an array of old liquors and spirits, half of the bottles coated in a thin layer of dust. Atop the counter was worn, brown radio scanner, and beside the bartop was a chalkboard, its surface marked with a series of words and numbers.

District 3

Jackel, Gold tooth	1 dead, 7 injured	1,600N - 1,000N
<u>Kostak</u>	<u>13 dead (1 minor)</u>	<u>4,000N - 3,200N</u>

District 4

Human, m, red hair	Theft, 3,244N	20% alive only
Ostrey	Theft, Assault, 4,780N	800N + 20% alive only
Mezzo, m, pink skin	2 dead, 12 injured	2,400N - 1,800N

King's Quarter

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District 7

Harlequin	6 dead (6 minor)	3,150N - 1,450N
Human, f, gas mask	1 dead (patrol)	4,000N alive only

The door slowly squeaked, its metal brushing against the stone floor. Melanie stepped in first, her body shrouded in a hooded grey windbreaker. She stood around five and a half feet tall (she had never bothered to measure the exact number), with a thin, lithe frame that blended in with the surrounding walls. Her black hair was cut short and perpetually lay in a messy nest atop her head, she had taken quite a lot of pride in her hair at some point in the

past. Melanie moved silently to the bar, flicking a switch near the booth to turn on the room's dim overhead lights.

Nebakin entered second, her fully yellow body standing out harshly against the darkness of the night beyond the door. She was a good foot taller than Melanie, her rectangular torso at least twice as wide. Her face, lacking any semblance of mouth, nose, ears, or hair, always seemed blank, no matter what she was looking at. Her hands were the only part of her that wasn't blindingly yellow. Four thick digits floated an inch from the nub end of each palm, each finger tinted light blue from being in a near constant state of frost. Her hands would shake on occasion, and sometimes, after an extended battle, her fingers would lock up, unable to bend or stretch for several minutes. Nebakin never acknowledged it, no matter how many times Melanie brought it up as a concern.

Melanie stepped behind the bartop, bending down to access a small lockbox partly hidden underneath the floormat. She removed a wad of crumbled notes from her jacket pocket, stuffing them inside the box before locking it shut. Nebakin walked to the chalk board and grabbed a damp rag from behind the counter, erasing the underlined words.

"Pity. That extra 800 would have fed you for another four days," Nebakin spoke softly. She reached to the radio, flicking a switch and adjusting its dial slowly. Crackling static sparked to life as the radio hissed and hummed. Melanie stood up from behind the bar table and pulled a whiskey glass from under the counter. The static chattered in beats, slowly following a rhythm, until the din of clicks and pops morphed into speech. A female voice began over the radio, pitchy and somewhat robotic.

"...826...827...828..."

Melanie's fingers glided over the bottles lining the back wall, passing over the dusty lids and landing on a well-loved bottle of cognac. She poured two-shots worth into her glass and leaned against the counter as Nebakin stared idly at the radio.

"...862...863...864..."

At the back of the room was a door leading into the kitchen. It was a small space, packed mostly with an assortment of dried and canned goods. Several empty boxes rested on a stovetop which had last been used when the bar was a bar. The fridge had long been left to frost over, now holding nothing but a half dozen mostly empty wine bottles. Across from the kitchen was a door marked "Employees Only," a walk-in closet now furnished with a twin sized mattress and a handful of newspaper clippings pasted to the walls. Beyond those two doors was the back room, a private space for shows. The room had been rearranged, chairs and tables pushed to the walls. A row of thick iron

bars separated the room in two, forming a cell large enough to comfortably house six people.

“904...905...906...”

As the last number was spoken, the voice disappeared, shrouded in a mist of flowing static. Melanie and Nebakin both perked up, Nebakin rising from her stool and stepping over to the chalkboard. At last, the hum of static cut faded, replaced by a deeper voice, that of a man in his 30s or 40s.

“2:42 am, 38th of Spring,” the voice began, his words methodical and well practiced. “District 1, four new bounties. An unidentified Branco male wanted for assault, theft, and attempted destruction of government property. At 9:38 pm on Spring 36th, suspect was reported entering a restricted government building through the third story window carrying an unidentified electronic device. Suspect attacked an individual on the third floor before continuing to the fifth floor...” The voice droned on, its tone and pace precise. Melanie leaned against the counter top as she polished off her glass, pouring herself another shot’s worth of the same drink.

“You sure you don’t want any?” Melanie asked with a slight grin, raising her glass in Nebakin’s direction. Nebakin ignored her, focus still fixed on the radio. The speaker continued on, listing the descriptions and crimes of wanted individuals in the same smooth tone.

“District 3, two new bounties.”

“Finally,” Melanie exhaled, slumping her elbows further on the counter and reaching over to turn the radio up a notch.

“Species unknown, sex unknown. Bestial appearance, brown, black, and tan streaked fur, approximately two and a half to three feet tall, five to five and a half feet long. Wanted on five counts of theft totaling in 4,831N, and two counts of assault. Each attack has targeted either electronics or metal exchanges, all victims left with severe slash and bite wounds, but no fatalities have been reported as of yet. Wanted for 800 Nero plus 20% value of stolen goods. Wanted alive only. Attacks began on Spring 26th, all concentrated in and around District 3. The last attack was located on 12th street in the Southernmost area of District 3.” Melanie let out a short, breathy laugh.

“Guess we’ve captured all the real threats if they’re just giving us petty thieves now.” Nebakin turned to the board as her partner spoke, erasing a section before adding a new line:

SUSU, bestial, dark fur Theft, Assault, 4831N 800N + 10% alive only

“They are concerned the creature is providing the stolen electronics to another individual,” Nebakin stated plainly as she wrote. Melanie raised her head with a slight tilt.

“How do you figure?”

“If it wanted money it would steal money. If it wanted food it would steal food. Electronics are not stolen out of necessity, they are stolen as a choice. But if the creature was the one making that choice, I doubt it would be leaving its victims alive.” Nebakin turned back to the radio, listening to its next bounty. Melanie sighed and slumped her head back on the counter.

“I dunno dude, maybe it eats RAM sticks or something.” Melanie finished off her glass and reached once more to the open bottle before changing her mind. Nebakin continued writing as the radio hissed, her movements mechanical yet loose, a dance performed a hundred times before.

“King’s Quarter, no new bounties,” the voice spoke. Melanie rolled her eyes as she placed the bottle of cognac back in its nesting spot.

“You think Patrol really cleaned up their act in that district alone? Or do they care so little they don’t even bother keeping tabs on crime there?” Nebakin tilted her hips slightly as she stared at the chalkboard.

“King’s Quarter is of higher class, I suppose it would not be too shocking to learn Patrol puts in enough funds to control that district alone.” Melanie cracked a smirk as she paced around the bar.

“Well I suppose I should be grateful they couldn’t give less of a shit about our district. We’d be out of a job if they cleaned up their act.” Melanie stepped over beside Nebakin as she continued writing. “Who’s the lucky winner tonight?” Nebakin paused, waiting for the voice on the radio to continue.

“District 8, three new bounties.” She reached over and flicked the switch, the radio crackling into silence. With a sharp inhale, she looked back to the board, arm raising to place one blocky finger over the words “SUSU.”

“This one.”

Melanie smiled and gave Nebakin a pat on the shoulder, resting her other hand around her waist.

“Right on, maybe we can see if your theory’s right about ‘em.” Melanie planted a soft kiss on Nebakin’s cheek before turning towards the walk in closet, moving slowly. “I’m calling it a night. Carrying that dude to the outpost was tiring as fuck.” Nebakin turned her head a notch to watch Melanie step away, before turning back to the board.

“Okay. I will be there soon,” her voice rang out, stale and quiet. She examined the board for a moment longer before moving, turning off the bar’s lights and following in Melanie’s footsteps.

Chapter 3

District 3 was an urban sprawl about twelve miles long and seven miles wide. Eighteen years ago, its perimeter had been sanctified via the construction of a fifteen foot stone wall built for 28 million Nero over the course of eleven months. It was the most the government had ever spent on a project concerning District 3. Passing between districts was not a hard task. At any given moment, there were only twelve patrolmen working to stand guard along the border: 3.16 square miles per officer. The wall itself was more symbolic than practical; it didn't keep people out, it didn't keep people in, it was simply a delineation.

District 3 had four unofficial 'neighborhoods' known only to the people who lived there. In the North, the area from Waterfront to East 232 street was known as The Greens. It was a nice area for the most part, tight streets flanked by shops, bars and take-out restaurants. The northernmost point looked out over a cliff face to the river separating District 3 from District 7. Despite its name, it only had one park, a courtyard stretching from 275th to 263rd. It was the only public park in District 3. There were no birds or insects to fertilize the flowers, so every year after winter, four patrolmen would have to spend a week planting new flowers and shrubbery along the walkways and fenceline of the park. The last time either Nebakin or Melanie had been in The Greens was three months ago when Nebakin had gone to capture a Mezzo wanted for the murder of a patrolman and his family. Someone else had gotten to them first, and the pair lost a chance at 8,000 Nero.

From the southernmost point of District 3 to West 151st street was Low Town. The area was heavily populated with old factory buildings, some of which were still in use, some of which had been converted to government warehouses, many were now prisons. Outside of its colossal factories, the stone streets of Low Town were lined with two and three story brick facades, reinforced and gated windows letting a touch of light into cramped store floors and two bedroom apartments home to families of five. It was the most densely populated neighborhood in District 3 at 72,000 people per square mile.

Electronics exchanges were fairly common in Low Town for the simple reason that people needed power. Without a centralized energy grid, citizens relied on battery powered generators, and electronics exchanges were the only places to buy batteries. 1000N to power a single floor of a building for a week.

Despite its population density, the streets were often empty. Curfew in District 3 didn't start until 6:00pm just before sunset, but hardly anyone left their house past noon. There was a sort of silent pact among the residents of

Low Town, a safety in numbers. At 9 a.m. every morning, one hour after sunrise, the streets would fill, bustling with the sound of footsteps and quick words. Residents would shop, talk, work, enjoy the sunlight; And by noon, the streets would once again be empty. At some point, an agreement had been made among the locals, unspoken and unbroken. The sheer numbers of the populace were enough to deter any would be criminal, you couldn't find a single shadow to retreat into. Then, the return to shelter and silence.

Located along 48th street—flanked by two, three story apartment buildings—was a storefront with orange signage, a sign in its window reading “Come back Tomorrow!” in curvy red font. The rolling security gate was pulled halfway up, its lock split open and laying in pieces on the ground. The store doors slammed open as a dark figure emerged, its body covered in matted fur and sweat, its jaw clutched tightly around the end of a rucksack. The creature tumbled out onto the sidewalk, slipping under the security gate and glancing back for a split moment into the store as the doors closed behind it. Its feet trailed splotches of blood as it moved. The creature turned and dashed down the sidewalk, moving quickly into the cover of a nearby alley. Shadowed on both sides, it took a moment to pause, breathing with heavy, slow breaths. The creature's body was an amalgam, stitched together chunks of fur and meat. The left side of its head was that of a jaguar, with the right being that of a hyena. Its body was a splotchy portrait, an imitation animal, bear hide, wolf and rodent fur peppered with snake and rhino skin, hooved back legs and clawed forelegs. With a long exhale, the creature regained itself, gripping the rucksack tighter in their jaw and looking ahead to the end of the alley.

Their eyes widened. Standing at the end of the alley was a figure, a human woman, her body clothed in a light grey jacket, holding a shotgun in one hand, the other wrapped tightly around a sheathed knife at her hipside. The creature frantically turned back to the alley entrance, seeing it blocked by another figure, a yellow humanoid, her eyes fixated on the creature like a predator animal. The beast was equidistant from either exit, its body now tense with adrenaline as it glanced between the two.

“5 robberies and 2 assaults, damages equal to 4831 Nero,” Nebakin spoke, the voice flat and authoritative.

“Make that 6 robberies,” the creature turned its head to face Melanie as the words left her lips. Nebakin paused, as if exhaling a long breath.

“6 robberies.”

Before she could continue, the creature pivoted its body, slamming a hooved foot into the stone strong enough for it to crack. It launched itself towards Nebakin, teeth still gripped tightly around the sack as its frantic eyes locked onto her figure. Nebakin dropped to the ground, her hands pressed up

against the cool stone before flashing a bright blue. Immediately a giant pillar of ice shot up from the ground, lifting her twenty feet into the air and completely blocking off the alley exit. The beast turned just in time to see Melanie's gun raised, its barrel flashing fire as buckshot hurdled through the air. They launched themselves towards one wall, pellets tearing through their side and sending streaks of blood across the ice behind them. The creature yelped like a dog, still keeping its teeth clenched as it bolted forward, the muscles in its legs burning with each thump along the ground. Melanie lined up to fire her next shot, feet planted to offset the gun's recoil. As she pulled the trigger, the beast suddenly dropped rucksack and leaped two yards into the air, landing parallel to one brick wall and pressing off it to propel forward. The air lit up with the smell of smoke as the gun fired, barely missing the creature as it collided with Melanie, knocking her to the ground with a sick crack. Fire shot through her spine as she collided with the stone, taking her out for only a moment. Using the creature's momentum, she shoved the creature past her, sending it tumbling into the street.

It stood back up, growling with the ferocity of a cornered animal as drops of blood continued to trickle from the shredded skin of its torso. Melanie jumped to her feet and unsheathed her dagger, waiting for the creature to approach first. It lunged teeth first, and she ducked and turned, the knife slashing through the air and catching the creature's outstretched arm. A thin line of blood splattered across her face as the creature landed behind her, forearms first. Pushing back as it landed, the creature kicked, a hoof violently slamming into Melanie's face, dislocating her nose with a wet crunch. She staggered, blood pouring out of each nostril. The creature turned, ready to launch itself once more, before the sound of rushing air caught its attention. From above, Nebakin dropped down from the rooftop, one hand coated in a thick layer of ice. Her fist collided with the creature's back, slamming it against the ground with the force of a speeding car as the ice shattered into dozens of sharp shards which dug into the creature's back. It let out a roar of pain, blood and spit sprinkling across the ground before it. The creature attempted to push its hands into the ground to realign itself, but its back shot with searing pain, its extremities quickly growing numb. As it struggled, Nebakin grabbed it by the neck and hoisted the creature into the air, slamming it against one of the alley walls. It cried once more, that frantic energy quickly leaving its eyes as its breaths turned shallow. Ice seeped out from Nebakin's grip, forming around the creature's neck and embedding into the surrounding wall. She finally let go, taking a step back to watch as the creature's body relaxed, held a foot above the ground and frozen to the wall behind it like an oversized shackle around its neck. The ice around its neck burned, it grabbed at it feebly a few

times before its arms finally fell to its side, the tightness around its neck forcing out shallow breaths.

Melanie stepped forward, her legs shaky, but her breathing now calmed. Blood still flowed out her broken nose, but in shorter waves now. She stared daggers into the eyes of the pinned creature, her hand still clutched tightly around the knife. Nebakin glanced at her, before gently resting a hand on Melanie's tightened fist.

"It is worth nothing to us dead." Her voice held no hint of compassion for either Melanie nor the creature, simply a statement of fact. Melanie turned to Nebakin, her teeth still gritted.

"It broke my fucking nose!" she spat out, her voice nasally and dry. "At least let me cut off this things stupid fuckin' donkey legs."

"You attacked me!" The voice caught the hunters both off-guard. It was gravelly and animalistic, but significantly more understandable than either expected given the beast's appearance. Its mouth hung open, breathing with heavy pants.

"You can talk?! Why the fuck didn't you say anything before?" Melanie shouted, stepping forward over a puddle of her own blood.

"Well you didn't exactly give me the opportunity," the beast growled back, speaking seemed to be quite tiring for it. It lowered its voice and panted softly between sentences.

"I was hoping to just run past that yellow thing, I don't want to fight." Melanie stepped forward, the creature's words seeming to infuriate her more than her broken nose.

"First off, don't call her a thing," she spat at it, fists clenched tighter.

"You did it first," the creature muttered back, clearly not having the energy to argue past that.

"And second," Melanie began, before taking a breath and stepping back as if suddenly possessed. "Let me introduce me and my partner." She flashed a slight smirk. "Nebakin and I here are hunters. We collect bounties on wanted criminals like yourself. Killers, thieves, monsters, urchins, anyone deemed dangerous enough for patrol to give a shit about, but not so dangerous that they actually wanna get off their asses and catch them themselves." Tossing her knife thoughtlessly back and forth between hands, Melanie's eyes fixated on the creature's face. "We aren't against killing bounties, especially if they're uncooperative or unpredictable, which—let's be honest, your type usually is. However, patrol prefers prisoners over corpses, and you're worth a fat zero if we turn you in dead. So it's in all our best interest if you just let us lead you over to the nearest station. We collect our payment, you get to live, we all go on our merry little ways."

The creature's breath quickened as she spoke, its eyes following the knife back and forth between her hands. The same frantic fire from before had fully reappeared.

"N-no... no, you can't turn me in," it began, its voice soft, verging on an air of defeat. "Please... you have to let me finish my job at least... I'm as good as dead if I don't give them those parts." Its voice sounded more strained with each spoken word. Nebakin and Melanie exchanged glances, Nebakin slowly turning to note the sack of stolen goods which had been so haphazardly spilt during their fight. She turned back, and Melanie could read the self-gratification in her eyes. *I told you so*. Melanie sighed and sheathed the knife.

"Ok fine, I'll bite. Who is this 'them' that's forcing you to steal radios and generators?" The creature hesitated at this, the ice around its neck singeing at its fur like a cold fire.

"I-I can't speak..." it finally let out in a soft whisper. Nebakin stepped closer now, moving right up to the creature and speaking plainly.

"With how thick your fur is, you have about thirty seconds before your skin cells begin to die. We may let you go, depending on what you tell us, but we need a name first before we can trust you. We need something we can hold over you, in case you try running away, something that will always come back to you."

The creature winced, feeling as if its vocal cords were on the verge of freezing solid. It gasped out, no longer able to inhale, whispering softly.

"R-river... Pig..." the air escaped its lips like steam from a kettle. Nebakin and Melanie exchanged glances, before Nebakin raised a hand and balled it into a fist, the ice trapping the creature shattering into a flurry of harmless snow. It fell to the ground with a thud, its throat opening up as it gasped and gulped down shallow breaths of air. Nebakin moved to tower over the creature, now curled against the wall.

"Continue," she urged with no real urgency. The creature glared up at her, its teeth slightly gritted, but its body was far too damaged to retaliate in any meaningful way now.

"River Pig... it's a crummy food joint in The Greens. That's where they make me bring the scrap once I get it. They... they have this huge basement..." It paused for a moment, still catching its breath, its voice slowly returning.

"What do they need all this shit for though?" Melanie said, motioning to the scattered mess of electronic parts. Nebakin turned away from the pair and paced over to the toppled appliances, seeming to just now process its existence, and slowly gathering them together back into the sack.

“I don’t fuckin’ know... does it look like they tell me anything? No, they tell me the location and I go, I steal the shit and get it back to them, I do whatever they tell me to, and if I don’t...” its voice trailed off as its breathing returned to a more manageable steady pace. Melanie tilted her head slightly in thought, Nebakin turned to look over the creature once more, squinting her eyes slightly.

“Who are these people you refer to?” Nebakin asked slowly. There was a long pause as the creature held back, somewhere between being unwilling to provide and answer, and unable to.

“They... made me I suppose...” it finally relented, its tone rejecting the idea even as it was spoken. Melanie knelt down, eyeing the creature with less skepticism than before.

“Something gives me the impression you aren’t a big fan of your creators.” She gave the creature a soft smirk, which it limply returned. “And if that’s the case, maybe we can help.” Nebakin gave Melanie a confused look as she returned with the sack, now refilled and reorganized. The creature seemed just as unclear on the implication, Melanie nevertheless returning to her feet and extending a hand to grab the creature’s forearm.

“I take it you still can’t walk straight.” It responded with a slight nod, and Melanie lifted the beast up onto her back as it let out a confused yelp. It struggled for a moment before once again going limp, its bottom half still mostly numb.

“Y-you’re not taking me to the station... are you?” it whimpered out meekly as Melanie began walking, Nebakin following along a few feet behind curiously.

“Nah—turning you in wouldn’t even pay for our electric for the week,” Melanie said with a scoff. “However, turning in a group of criminals who illegally catalyze hybrids like yourself, that’ll bring in some serious Nero.” The creature still seemed concerned about this new prospect, but it certainly wasn’t in a position to argue. The three moved quickly along the empty sidewalk, walking North to District 3’s Center City.